

Q But compared to the experience Red Hat has had with Linux and open source, how do you slot yourself on the same level of expertise?

In the late 90s, there was something called 'network computers'. That was a long time ago. What people don't know is they were actually based on Linux. We developed that network computer based on Linux, and that is the Linux engineering team we still have today. Lots of people in the industry don't know that we were providing patches to Linux for our large Oracle customer base even though they had active Red Hat subscriptions. It was long before we announced our Linux programme.

So, you can say that we have been in the Linux support business unofficially for quite some time. You think Red Hat has got all those big names, like Alan Cox [editor's note: till recently, as he's joined Intel in January 2009], contributing to it. That's true! But we too benefit from the same engineers. And I don't think that we are at a different contributing level from Red Hat. If you look at the contributors to the Linux Foundation, Oracle is quite high on that list. And if people still say that we don't contribute that much, it's not fair.

If you look at the large number of projects in the open source community that are freely running, Berkeley DB is a major one. It is a major contribution we have made—released under a dual licence. Although Oracle has been a good open source corporate citizen, I can't figure out why people don't want to give us credit for it.

Q Oracle Enterprise Linux is based on RHEL, so is CentOS. And when people talk about RHEL alternatives, or clones, CentOS comes to mind immediately. Oracle Enterprise Linux is pretty much unheard of.

What does CentOS do? They pick up RH, remove logos and trademarks, and redistribute it. In our view, there should no longer be a CentOS. It takes more time to consolidate servers on the Linux side, and as much as we can, we are doing exactly the same thing. But we are investing a lot of technical resources also.

Q What kind of presence do you have in the LUGs around the world?

What kind of people go to the LUGs? Are the enterprise customers we are talking about, those who are on top of the pyramid, there? In LUGs you go about spreading the word about what you are doing. That is not a core focus of our market. Is it important? Yes, of course it is, if there is an Ubuntu vs Debian vs CentOS sort of debate. But this is not the kind of market we are in. Our sweet spot is the enterprise customer who wants our support.

Q But don't you think a lot of developers who influence decision makers are active LUG members?

If we had the resources we will also go to the LUGs but, as I said, that is not our focus area. If I have to choose between LUGs and CIOs, I will go the CIO path. It's not that we are denying their importance, it's just a matter of

the bandwidth that we have. Most of the LUGs are also non-Oracle shops, generically.

Q So, what do you have that other Linux vendors don't? We've a feature called premium backporting. So, imagine that this October 1, you have a project to start that is meant to end on December 31. In these three months, you do all kinds of testing. Two months later, after a hard-core testing phase, you find a bug that's affecting the entire stack. What are the options you're left with now to fix the problem?

Traditional Linux vendors will say upgrade to the latest version of that package and you will inherit whatever has been changed in that package—enhancements, new features, other bug fixes... whatever. Oracle customers said this is not acceptable. They don't want any 'delta' between fixing their problem and other stuff, because it increases the risk. They want that one bug to be fixed in that specific version of the package that they are using.

What Oracle says is, if you want to have that level of support, we offer it. It's never been offered ever before in the enterprise Linux space. If someone can do it, it's good. But it required a significant amount of resources from the engineering point of view. This is what our customers are saying they need from Linux. A little bit more support to promote that adoption. Okay, we do it, so now you can adopt Linux!

Q But even if you look at Red Hat, they are still supporting RHEL 3 and RHEL 4, with a pretty outdated software stack.

I want to give you some specific examples. Let's say you've got GCC version 2.3, and now you have found a bug that needs to be fixed. But by this time, Red Hat may have added 2.4, 2.5, 2.6, etc. So when you approach them for the fix, their answer will be to upgrade to the latest version of that package for that release. The situation is like, you are at GCC 2.3, the latest RHEL package for GCC is 2.76, or whatever, which means there is a gap there. For an enterprise, every new feature inside a version is a risk. So what you want is that one bug fixed, and not have to upgrade to that latest version packed in the RHEL release. I'm not saying from RHEL 3 to RHEL 5; I'm talking about packages inside those release chains. So wherever we jump from one version to another, there can be several changes. This is a risk. Customers don't want to see that, but that's the answer they get from Red Hat.

But what we do is find the bug in that package and fix it in the same version, and give it to the customer. It has never been done by any one, as it involves significant amounts of engineering. If the customer is okay to upgrade to whatever package in that release, then it's okay; you don't need that premium backporting feature.

I'm just telling you the difference between Red Hat and us; and there is another very important thing—we offer life-time support. So for concepts like RHEL 3 reaching 'end of life', there is no such thing with Oracle Enterprise Linux—we support that forever. The same is the case with